

GREAT GUNSMITHS

STEYR-MANNLICHER

FERDINAND
RITTER VON
MANNLICHER

Steyr-Mannlicher, a celebrated Austrian firearms manufacturer, began as a very traditional maker of weapons, but has also embraced innovation and change. The company's founder, Josef Werndl, came from a family of metalworkers, so he could draw on experience stretching back over many generations. However, his company made rapid progress in the 1860s, when Werndl began to collaborate with Austrian designer Ferdinand Ritter von Mannlicher, especially on innovative rifle designs.

The city of Steyr, near the confluence of the Enns and Steyr rivers in Upper Austria, has been a metalworking center since at least the 13th century. Weapons manufacture became a major industry in the area around the time of the Thirty Years' War (1618–48), when the region supplied muskets and pistols to the Hapsburg Army. During the 19th century, this tradition continued, and one Steyr metalworker, Leopold Werndl, sent his son Josef to the US to learn about the latest ideas in firearms production. By the late 1860s, Josef was in control of the family firm and was delivering thousands of breech-loading rifles to the Austro-Hungarian Army.

ROOTS IN TRADITION

Josef Werndl's company, the Österreichische Waffenfabriksgesellschaft (Austrian Weapons Manufacturing Company), prospered in the second half of the 19th century, combining modern production methods with a traditional use of craft skills. A turning point came in 1885, when the Austro-Hungarian Army adopted its new bolt-action rifle, which was the brainchild of Ferdinand Ritter von Mannlicher. Mannlicher, who also invented the en bloc clip for loading cartridges, eventually became the company's chief designer, and the firm's name changed to Steyr-Mannlicher. He was successful again with the Mannlicher Schönaauer full-stock rifle, a hunting weapon that he designed with Otto Schönaauer, the director



of the company. By this time, the company had established a prime position in both sporting and military markets.

Mannlicher died in 1904, but the company continued to build on its tradition and introduced new models, notably pistols, including the self-loading M1912, and also built a new factory, much larger than its predecessor and with the latest machinery. This new plant enabled the company to turn out firearms in large numbers, and was in place just in time to fulfill the huge surge in demand triggered by World War I. The firm

▲ QUALITY CONTROL

Careful quality control is at the heart of successful firearms production. Here a worker undertakes a manual check on a gun barrel at the Steyr-Mannlicher factory.

soon employed around 15,000 people and even branched out into products such as bicycles and aircraft engines. However, the postwar treaty signed by Austria severely diminished the country and imposed economic limitations on it. The size of its army and the production of weapons were restricted. As a result, Steyr-Mannlicher faced difficulties. It only staved off bankruptcy by concentrating on products other than weapons, particularly bicycles and cars, which it had begun to manufacture during the war.

THE MODERN COMPANY

Large-volume production of firearms began again at Steyr during World War II, but the factory suffered damage from Allied bombing. After the war, the production of weapons was

“There is no figure in the history of firearms who can approach the great Austrian inventor, Ferdinand Ritter von Mannlicher ...”

ATTRIBUTED TO W. H. B. SMITH, AUTHOR OF “SMALL ARMS OF THE WORLD”